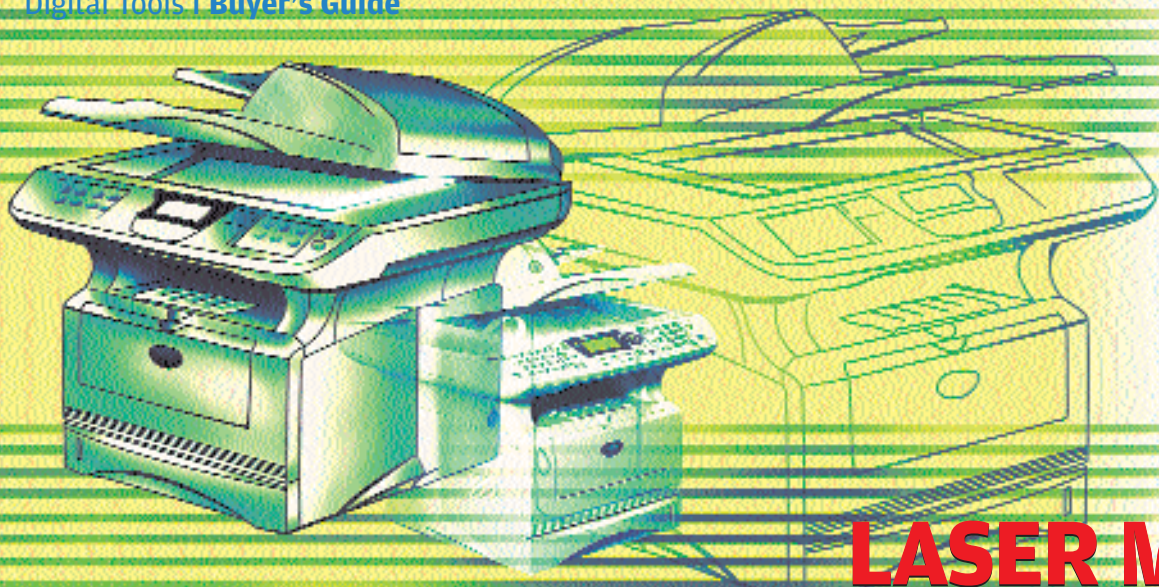




An MFD or multifunction device combines the features of copying, faxing, printing and scanning into a single unit. This is a sought-after commodity by small and medium offices because space is of prime importance, and since an MFD packs in the functionality of so many devices in a single unit, it saves that much space and cost.

Laser MFDs are more expensive than their inkjet counterparts, but they offer superior print quality and are much faster. They also require lower maintenance, and boast of a very low cost per printed page. As a result, the popularity of laser MFDs is on the rise. These are basically printer-based MFDs, and hence have a higher cost per page and lower page per minute than copier-based MFDs. But they cost a lot lower than their copier-based counterparts.

A copier-based MFD is nothing but a digital copier with added functionality, and has a separate toner cartridge and drum—whereas a printer-based MFD is less complex, and has these two integrated into a single toner drum.

Questions to ask the dealer

What type of PC interface does it have?

Most laser MFDs support the USB 2.0 interface. However, if you are going to connect it to an old PC, you should look for a parallel interface, which will most likely be the only interface available on that PC.

What is the toner and printer duty cycle?

The printer duty cycle is the number of pages the printer can print in a month at default quality settings. The toner duty cycle is the total number of pages that the toner can print. Needless to say, look for a higher number.

Does it support duplex printing?

Duplex printing means the ability to print on both sides of the paper. This eliminates the need for manually flipping the paper and putting it back in. This is useful for printing booklets, manuals and such.

Does it have networking support?

Small and medium businesses generally have a network consisting of a small number of computers, so you should look for an MFD with network support.

Is the MFD upgradeable?

Pay attention to upgradeability and scalability. Upgrade options will extend the functionality of the device as your needs grow.

What type of warranty is being offered?

Laser MFDs are heavy—lugging them



around is not feasible; make sure your model is covered by an on-site warranty.

Usage Tip

Not all MFDs have the fax feature. If you're not planning on using fax, or if you already have a fax machine, you can save a little by investing in an MFD without the fax feature.

Points To Ponder

What are the advantages of a laser MFD?

Laser MFDs print at the most economical rate and have the lowest running cost. They are very fast and their print quality is also very high.

Are there any disadvantages of an MFD over discrete devices?

Yes. If, for example, the scanner of the MFD stops working for some reason, the copier also will not function since it depends on the scanner.

What type of an MFD should I buy?

Consider your usage pattern. If you print less and copy more, choose a copier engine-based MFD. If you print more and copy less, opt for a

printer engine-based MFD. If fax is your main concern, opt for a specialised laser fax, which doubles as a laser printer and scanner.

What other features should I look for?

Look for features such as paper capacity, buffer memory, duplex printing, toner save, etc. Make sure the MFD can print on the kinds of paper products you use, such as envelopes and index cards.

Does it have a user friendly interface?

Try the console interface to figure out how to operate the device. Check out the control panel. It should have a good LCD panel to display status messages and warnings.

The Future

The next few years will see a lot of exciting innovations in the laser MFD segment. LEP (liquid electro-photo-graphic) technology used in high-end digital printing presses has the potential to revolutionise office and home printing alike. Other innovations such as printing over wireless are already on their way to market. Direct printing from cell phones is another possibility that is being explored. Similarly, there are advancements being made in the field of scanners. And with Wi-Fi gaining popularity in offices, Wi-Fi capable MFDs are something to look forward to in the near future! ■